



THE BULLPEN

By Lester Koelling

PAIR OF HELPERS ARRIVE

HOLLYWOOD, Fla.—Two of several major problems on the Indianapolis baseball club may have been solved today with the arrival of Catcher John (Honey) Romano and Shortstop Don Prohovich on option from the Chicago White Sox.

"Both have the potential to make our club," said Manager Andy Cohen, who has seen them perform in Chisox exhibition games, "and if they do, they could solve two of our biggest problems. We're going to give them a good shot."

Of the two, the White Sox organization is highest on Prohovich, who was graduated only last summer from Holy Cross University. He's big for a shortstop, standing 6.1 and weighing 185 pounds. He swings from the left side of the plate and batted .284 in 71 games for Colorado Springs last year in his first pro experience.

"He's our shortstop until he proves he can't handle the position," said Cohen. "I like his hitting better than his fielding. His arm isn't too strong, but that may come. He's got good power and should hit us some home runs. He looks like a natural hitter."

Cohen's appraisal of Prohovich as a hitter was corroborated by Bonnie Huffman, a Chisox scout who signed the boy in hot competition with several other major league clubs.

"Don is what you would call a smart hitter," said Huffman, a former major league catcher who is assisting in the farm camp operations here. "He hits the ball where it's pitched and doesn't try to pull everything like so many other young fellows. He's a good student of the game and is always trying to improve himself and learn more about his position."

Huffman scouted Prohovich four years, starting in 1952 when Don played in a college semipro league, regarded as the toughest nonpro loop in the country. He also followed the boy in the Nova Scotia semipro league where he competed against several former major leaguers.

"The boy was a real good student in school," added Huffman, "and he's a great competitor. I wouldn't hesitate to say that he can play Triple A ball and I'll add that if he does, you will see him improve as the season progresses. If he comes through, it will be a big break for your club and also for Prohovich."

Tribe President Ownie Bush is another observer who sees great potential in Prohovich.

"I like the way he swings that bat," said Bush.

"He's got some things to learn in the field, but that will come. After all, he's only a kid, just out of college. But he showed me something with that bat and he hits the curve ball good."

So that's the preview on Prohovich by men who have seen him in action. What develops remains to be seen.

In Romano, the Indians are receiving a catcher who set a home run record for the Three-I League in 1955. He

walloped 38 four-baggers with Waterloo that year and lead the league in RBI's with 124.

He was with two clubs last year, starting with Memphis and finishing with Vancouver in the Pacific Coast League. There he batted .241 with eight homers in 88 games. He's 5.11, weighs 215 pounds and is a native of New Jersey.

First-Came Jitters

THERE WASN'T anything particular to disturb Manager Cohen in the Tribe's 7-4 loss to Buffalo here yesterday.

"After all," explained Cohen, "it was our first game and we had some youngsters out there who made mistakes that wouldn't happen with veterans. But I'm not complaining. I think we did very well and I was especially pleased with our pitching."

Al Papai, the knuckleballer, worked the first three innings and was touched for three unearned runs when Dick Ditusa dropped a fly ball in left. The only runs earned by the Bisons was one off Terry Loy, a Colorado Springs employee who worked the middle three, and one off Tony Ponce, who tossed the last three.

The Indians matched Buffalo's hit total at 12, but four errors meant the difference. Brightest Indianapolis performance was turned in by Dick Means, an outfielder from Colorado Springs who connected for two solid hits, stole a base, and threw out a runner at third.

The two clubs were to meet again today in nearby Pompano Beach where the Bisons train. The Buffalo roster contains several former Indianapolis players including Pete Castiglione, the popular shortstop in 1947 and '48; Steve Nagy, a pitcher on the '47 club; Rod Graber, who started the season with the Indians last year, and Luke Easter, who spent a part of the '53 campaign with the Tribe.

SAMMY ESPOSITO, a flop at third base for the Chicago White Sox last year, is making a strong bid to remain as the team's No. 1 utility infielder. The former Indiana University athlete has been filling in for injured Shortstop Luis Aparicio and doing an excellent job. Aside from his timely hitting, including three blows against Cincinnati Sunday, Esposito has sparked in the field.




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